

Be a Competitor: Love Your Adversaries, Featuring Phillip Fulmer

Coach Pat Summitt

You have to love your adversaries. They make you better. They force you to improve, to stretch your capacities. Competitors respond to a challenge from their opponents and to negative motivation, as well as to positive. Competitors seek revenge for losses. They crave a compliment if they haven't had one. They are constantly asking, "Did I do the right thing? Was I good enough?"

Competitors want to prove everyone else wrong. They want to show skeptics, "I am better than this. I am a winner."

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It can be a hard thing to have love and gratefulness for your opponents. After all, they're the ones standing in the way of your success.

But as the saying goes, "If you want to be the best, you have to beat the best." True competitors never stop challenging themselves, and they don't play it safe. You have to be willing to dream big, work hard, and take risks. Otherwise, you'll never grow. Your competition will work just as hard as you at gaining an advantage. They'll expose your weaknesses and try to capitalize on them.

Great adversaries force you to improve. In leadership, you have to constantly be finding ways to grow so that you can be ready to handle those tough situations that come along right before a major breakthrough. How do you seek out being challenged so you can grow in your field? Who are the competitors that push you to be greater? These rivals are crucial to the development of your talent and stamina for success, even if you fall short and take losses en route to meeting your ultimate goals.

Good competition will keep you focused. There was no other competitor the 1997 Lady Vols team respected more than Connecticut. Tennessee had suffered a humiliating loss to them during the regular season. When the team found out that Tennessee and Connecticut would be in the same bracket for the tournament, the players were excited. Not only did Tennessee beat Connecticut 91 to 81, the team's competitive drive gave them the motivation and hunger they needed to go on and win the NCAA championship for the second year in a row.

Be grateful for your opponents. It's a sign of respect to take your rival seriously. Doing so will allow you to discover new areas for improvement and take the team that you lead to another level.

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Your competitors make you better. Having a worthy adversary stimulates your work ethic and brings out qualities you may not have known you had. So, don't resent them. You should love your competitors and you should thank them.